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Employee Offboarding and Account Termination

Leaver accounts, access removal, device return, mailbox handling and data retention

Default priority: P3 Medium
(P1 for urgent security terminations)**Target response / resolution:** Immediate for security cases / on the last working day otherwise**Handled by:** Tier 2, with Security and HR

Scope

Use this instruction when an employee, contractor, or intern leaves, moves roles, or needs urgent access removal. It protects company data and ensures licences and equipment are recovered.

Related instructions: WI-09 Access Requests, WI-02 Onboarding, WI-18 Asset Management

Common symptoms

- HR notice of a resignation or end of contract
- Manager requests removal of access for a leaver
- Urgent termination request from HR or Security
- Access remains after someone changes teams

Information to collect

- Name, employee ID, last working day, and time of access removal
- Whether the termination is standard, urgent, or sensitive
- Manager and nominated person for mailbox and file handover
- Equipment issued and any pending returns

Resolution steps

- 1 Confirm the request.** Accept offboarding requests only from HR or the line manager through the approved process. Confirm the dates and whether this is an urgent security removal.
- 2 Time the access removal.** For standard exits, schedule account disablement for the end of the last working day. For urgent cases, disable immediately and revoke active sessions.
- 3 Disable and secure the account.** Disable sign-in, reset the password, revoke sessions and tokens, remove MFA methods, and remove the user from groups and distribution lists.
- 4 Handle mailbox and files.** Set an out-of-office or forwarding to the manager as approved. Convert to a shared mailbox or apply retention as per policy. Transfer file ownership and cloud storage content to the manager.
- 5 Recover equipment.** Arrange the return of the laptop, phone, tokens, and badge. Record the asset tags, wipe devices after data has been secured, and update the register.
- 6 Remove licences and external access.** Remove software licences, application accounts, VPN access, and any third-party access. Check shared accounts and update shared passwords the person knew.
- 7 Confirm and record.** Verify the account is disabled and has no active sessions. Attach the completed checklist and the approvals, and set the deletion date according to the retention policy.

Escalate when

- Termination involves a dispute, investigation, or legal hold (involve HR, Legal, and Security)
- Evidence of data copying or unusual activity before departure
- Equipment is not returned, or a device is lost

Resolution and closure

- Attach the offboarding checklist and the date and time access was removed
- Update the asset register and licence tracker
- Close after the equipment is returned and the retention date is set

Quick troubleshooting reference

Symptom	Likely cause	What to do
Leaver account still active after the last day	Notification missed	Disable now, review sign-in activity since the last day, and tell Security.
Manager needs the leaver's files	File ownership unclear	Transfer cloud files to the manager and give access to shared folders with approval.
Leaver's mail still receiving customer emails	No forwarding or out-of-office	Set approved forwarding or convert to a shared mailbox for a limited time.
Laptop not returned	Leaver delay or loss	Chase through the manager and HR, lock the device remotely, and record an incident if lost.
Contractor needs extended access	Contract extended	Get written approval and set a new end date. Do not leave accounts open without one.

Suggested wording for the user

Open	<i>"I am processing the leaver request. Can you confirm the last working day and who should take over the mailbox and files?"</i>
During	<i>"The account will be disabled at the end of business on the last day. I will set the mailbox handover as you have asked."</i>
Close	<i>"All access is removed and your files are with you. Please make sure the laptop and accessories are returned to us by Friday."</i>

Good practice

Do

- Disable on the agreed date and time
- Transfer data before deleting anything
- Update shared passwords the person knew
- Record every action in the ticket

Do not

- Do not delete the account straight away
- Do not give the manager the leaver's password
- Do not act on requests that did not come from HR or the manager
- Do not forget third-party and contractor access

Worked example

A senior engineer resigns, with a last working day on Friday, and a request arrives on Wednesday.

Ticket note field	Entry
Issue reported	HR notice: last day Friday, handover to the team lead.
Checks performed	Verified HR approval. Account has admin access to two systems.
Cause	Standard leaver.
Action taken	Scheduled disablement for Friday 17:30. Transferred files, set mailbox forwarding, rotated shared admin passwords, and collected the laptop.
Result	Account disabled on time. Retention date set for 90 days.

Frequently asked questions

Q. What if a manager asks for a leaver's email contents?

Follow the policy: access is granted by HR or Legal approval, not just the manager's request. Record the approval and the scope.

Q. Should we delete a leaver's data immediately?

No. Keep it for the retention period, and check for legal holds first. Delete only on the scheduled date after confirmation.

Q. What about accounts used by several people?

List them in the offboarding checklist and change their passwords when someone who knew them leaves.

Analyst checklist

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Confirm the request | ☐ Remove licences and external access |
| ☐ Time the access removal | ☐ Confirm and record |
| ☐ Disable and secure the account | ☐ Ticket note completed using the standard template |
| ☐ Handle mailbox and files | ☐ User confirmed the issue is resolved |
| ☐ Recover equipment | |

Preventing repeat tickets

- Connect HR leaver events to the Service Desk automatically
- Keep a list of shared accounts and their owners
- Review privileged accounts every quarter
- Run monthly checks for active accounts of leavers